

Cover Letters

IB 514: Scientific Writing

What Cover Letters Do

Cover Letters

Function

Structure

Activity

Strategic Functions:

- **Provide context:** Summarize the key contribution and significance
- **Journal fit:** Convince the editor your work belongs in their journal
- **Frame the manuscript:** Guide the editor's interpretation before peer review
- **Manage the review:** Disclose conflicts, acknowledge related work
- **Professional communication:** First impression with an editor

Key Principle

Even though the manuscript contains the scientific argument, the cover letter **frames it** for the editor—it's often the first thing they read.

Suggested Structure

Cover Letters

Function

Structure

Activity

Each paragraph has a specific strategic function.

- 1 **Opening:** Introduce manuscript + central finding + broader significance
- 2 **Contribution:** How the research supports your main claim
- 3 **Journal Fit:** Why this manuscript belongs in this journal
- 4 **Compliance:** Required editorial declarations
- 5 **Closing:** Thank the editor + signature

Try keep it under 1 page. Be concise and professional.

Today's Activity

Cover Letters

Function

Structure

Activity

Groups of 3-4 people.

- 1 Share your reverse outlines: *what structure(s) did you observe?*
- 2 Compare to my template: *similarities and differences?*
- 3 Discuss strategic choices: *Why organize information these ways?*
- 4 *Outline* your own cover letter.
 - 1 High-level: What structure will you use? What information will go in each paragraph?
 - 2 Low-level: What specific points will you make in each paragraph?
- 5 Start *drafting* your letter (time permitting).

Remember

The template and examples are only a starting point.
Personalize them to match your voice.